



Te Tāhuhu o
te Mātauranga
Ministry of Education

Education Indicator

STUDENT ENGAGEMENT / PARTICIPATION

Reasons for student absence - Term 1 2026

Time recorded as absent in Term 1 2026 accounted for 9.2% of total class time. This was a decrease from 9.7% in Term 1 2025. Justified absences made up 5.7% of class time and unjustified absences made up 3.5% in Term 1 2026.

Indicator description

Proportion of term time absent for justified and unjustified reasons.

Proportion of students who are absent without justification for five or more full days in a single term.

Why this is important

The indicator of proportion of time absent for justified and unjustified reasons helps us understand the main reasons given for student absences. Understanding patterns of justified and unjustified absences can provide insights into what support may be needed to increase student attendance and engagement.

Presence or absence is recorded for each student at least twice during a school day by assigning an attendance code for each period of the day. These attendance codes indicate the presence or absence of the student and incorporate the reason for any absence. An absence is considered justified or unjustified based on the reason for absence.

Justified reasons for absence include: short-term illness or medical reasons; students stood down or suspended; students who are with a family member on an overseas posting and absences justified within school policy.

Unjustified reasons for absence include: holidays during term time; the reason is explained but is not justified within the school's policy; no information is provided or the explanation is trivial; and absences where the reason is unknown.

The frequency with which presence or absence is recorded depends on the type of school and the timetable. For example, most primary schools record attendance only twice a day. A secondary school is likely to record student attendance for each class and therefore multiple times per day.

Short-term illness and unjustified reasons for absence

Short-term illness/medical absences continued to be the main driver of non-attendance, accounting for 4.7% of absent time in Term 1 2026. Unjustified absences declined to 3.5% of total term time in Term 1 2026, from 4.0% in Term 1 2025. Absence recorded as truancy or unknown reason accounted for 1.6% of term time.

Changes to attendance codes

From Term 1 2025 a new set of attendance codes was introduced. Some attendance codes have been combined with others, within the relevant category of present, justified absence or unjustified absence. Justified absence for an overseas posting has been combined under the Justified (Other) absence code. All other code changes are within the Present codes. More information about the attendance code changes, including a full revised code list and decision tree, can be found here - [Attendance codes - Ministry of Education](#).

How are we going?

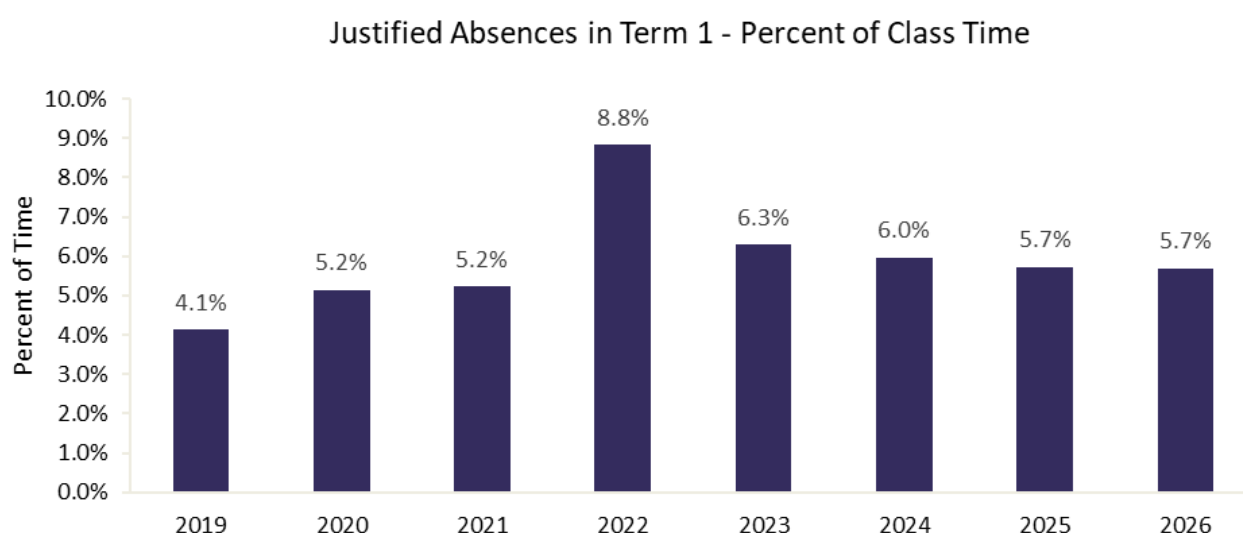
Time recorded as absent in Term 1 2026 accounted for 9.2% of total class time. This is a decrease from 9.7% in Term 1 2025. Justified absences made up 5.7% and unjustified absences made up 3.5% of class time in Term 1 2026.

Justified absences

Justified absences consist of absences due to short-term illness/medical reasons, stand-downs or suspensions and other absences justified within school policy.

In Term 1 2026, time recorded as justified absence remained unchanged from Term 1 2025 at 5.7%.

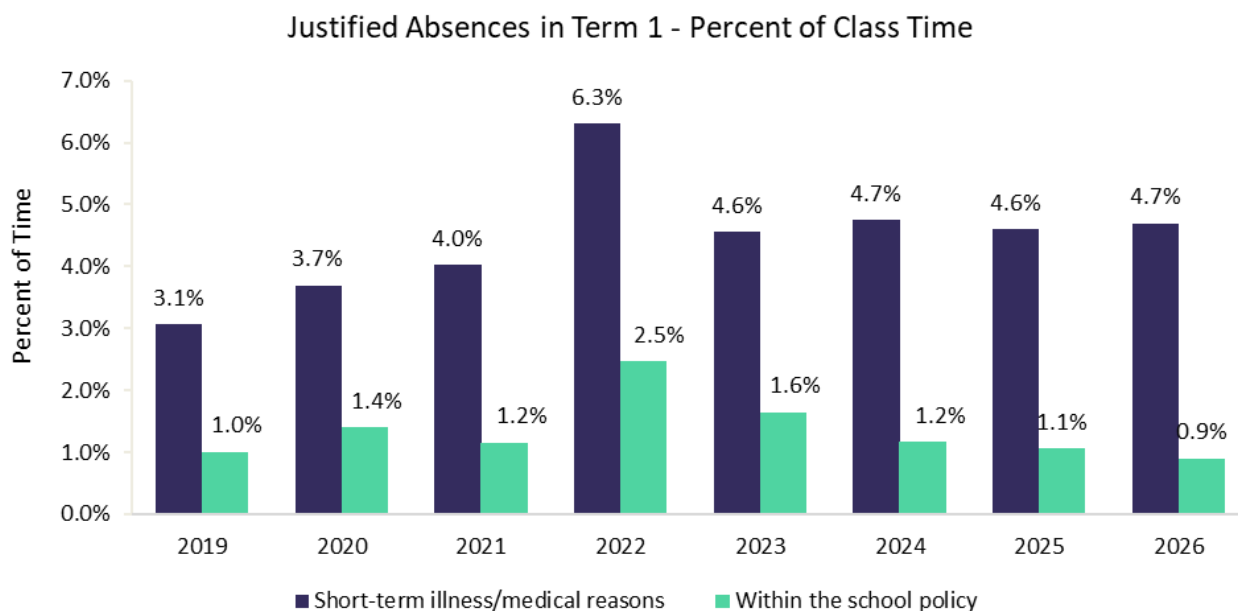
Figure 1: Justified absences in Term 1 - Percent of class time



Absences due to short-term illness/medical reasons were the largest contributor to justified absences, making up 4.7% of time in Term 1 2026, an increase of 0.1 percentage points from Term 1 2025.

The percentage of absent time for other justified reasons within school policy decreased from 1.1% of time in Term 1 2025 to 0.9% in Term 1 2026.

Figure 2: Justified absences in Term 1 – Percent of class time



During 2020 and 2021 the justified absence rate due to short-term illness/medical reasons was lower. Both these effects are likely due to government COVID-19 responses at the time to reduce the spread of the virus.

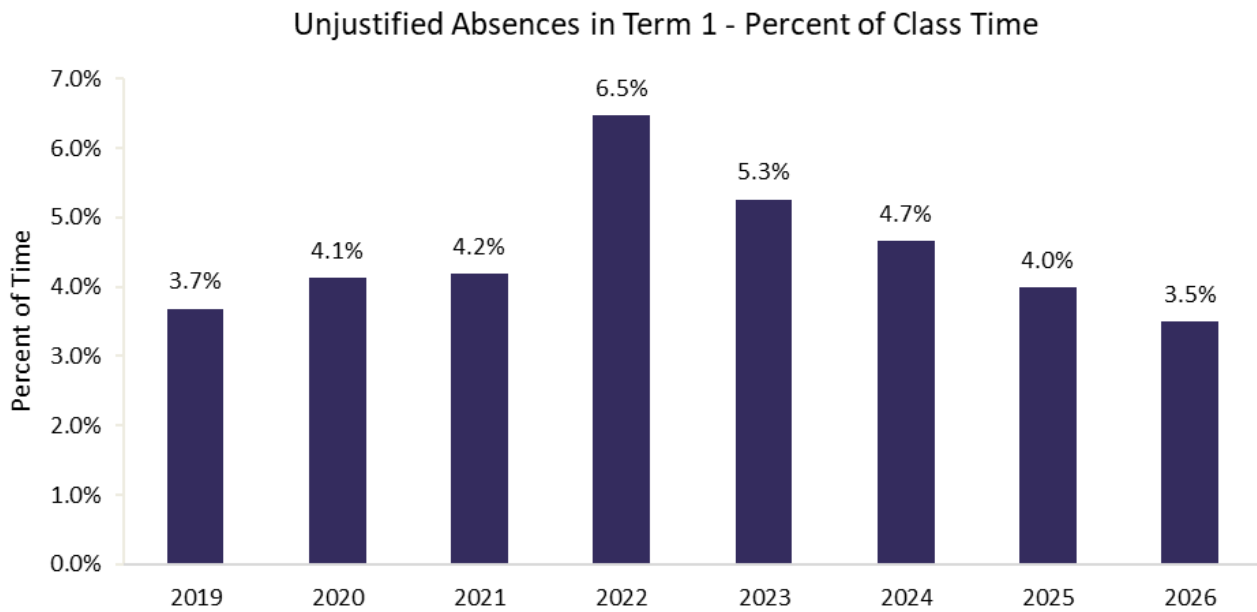
Unjustified absences

Unjustified absences consist of absences for explained but unjustified reasons, holidays during term time, truancy/throw-away explanations and unknown reasons.

Class time recorded as unjustified absence decreased between Term 1 2025 and Term 1 2026.

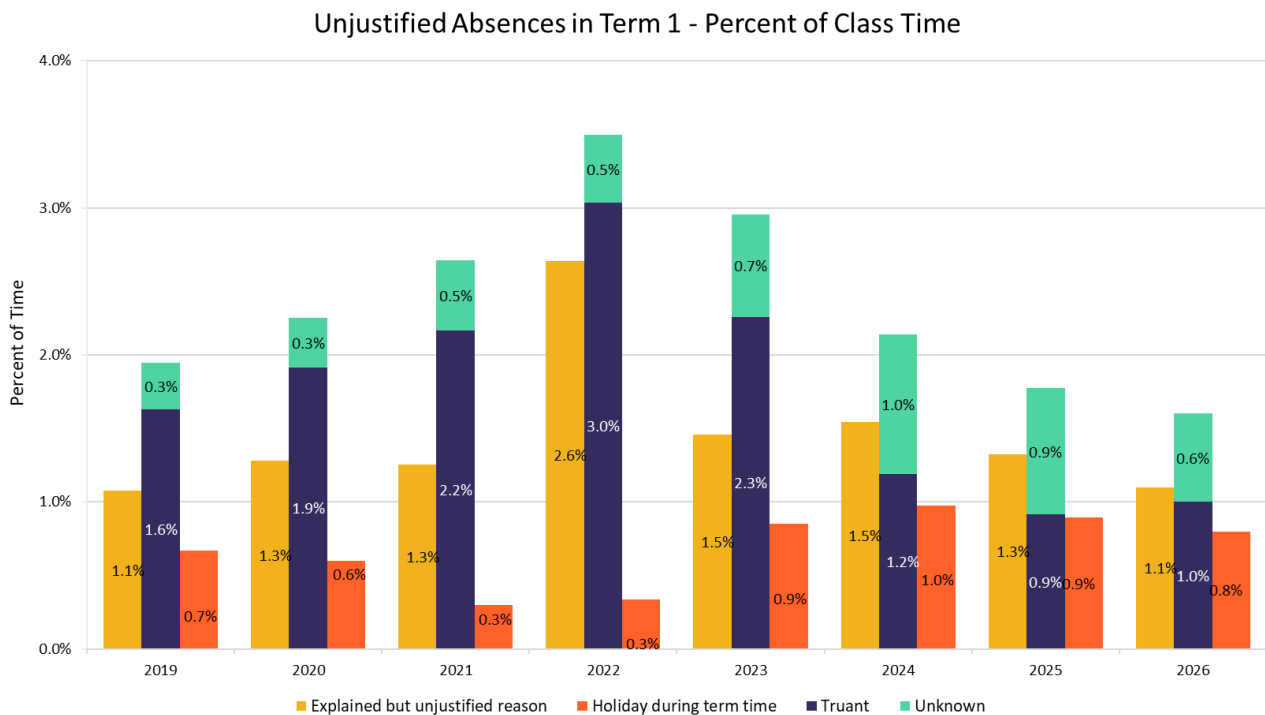
Unjustified absences made up 3.5% of time in Term 1 2026, down from 4.0% in Term 1 2025.

Unjustified absences have declined for the fourth consecutive year, down from a peak of 6.5% in 2022.

Figure 3: Unjustified absences in Term 1 - Percent of class time

Within unjustified absences, absences due to truancy (where no reason was given) or absences for an unknown reason together accounted for 1.6% of term time in Term 1 2026, a decrease from 1.8% in Term 1 2025.

The time absent that was explained but not justified under school policy decreased from Term 1 2025 (1.3%) to Term 1 2026 (1.1%). In Term 1 2026, time absent due to holidays during term time (0.8%) decreased from Term 1 2025 (0.9%).

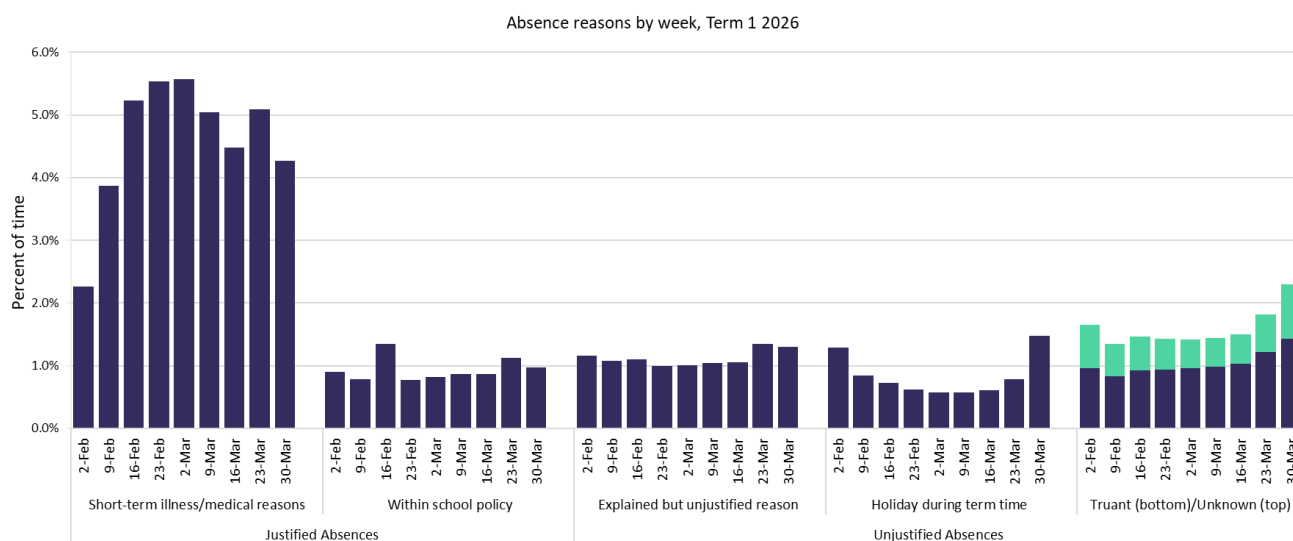
Figure 4: Unjustified absences in Term 1 – Percent of class time

Absence reasons by week

Absences due to short-term illness/medical reasons were the largest contributor to absence in every week in Term 1 2026. The percentage of time absent for short term illness/medical reasons reached a high of 5.6% during the first week of March. Absences that were within school policy remained between 0.8%-1.3%.

For unjustified absences, absences with an explained but unjustified reason remained steady at around 1.0%-1.3% throughout the term. In Term 1 2026, absences due to holidays during term time was 1.5% in the last week of the term.

Figure 5: Absence reasons by week, Term 1 2026 – Percent of Class Time



Where to find out more

For information on the Government's strategy to lift school attendance:

- [Increasing school attendance - Ministry of Education](#)

To obtain more information about student attendance, consider publications:

- [Attendance | Education Counts](#)
- [Daily attendance | Education Counts](#)
- [School attendance codes](#)
- [Attendance under COVID-19](#)
- [He Whakaaro: School Attendance and Student Wellbeing, Ministry of Education, February 2020](#)
- [He Whakaaro: What is the relationship between attendance and attainment? Ministry of Education, February 2020](#)

To obtain information about other forms of student engagement consider indicators:

- [Stand-downs, suspensions, exclusions and expulsions from school](#)
- [Early leaving exemptions](#)
- [Transient students](#)
- [School leaver's attainment](#)